

Euroskeptics steal the spotlight

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Presented by Connect Europe By NICHOLAS VINOCUR GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Politics is heating up around Europe — let's dive in. AfD WINS BIG IN SA

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By NICHOLAS VINOCUR

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Politics is heating up around Europe — let's dive in.

AfD WINS BIG IN SAXONY-ANHALT: Voters in the German state have given the far right its biggest electoral success in Germany since World War II, Nette Nöstlinger and James Angelos report.

With almost all ballots counted, the Alternative for Germany was on track last night for about 44 percent of the vote, a landslide on high turnout that would give it 39 seats in the regional parliament — just shy of the 42 seats needed to rule outright. The result is a catastrophe for Chancellor Friedrich Merz's Christian Democratic Union, whose support crashed to less than 18 percent, down from 37.1 percent in 2021.

What now? The AfD's national co-leader Alice Weidel said the party had "a very clear mandate for governing," though its local leader Ulrich Siegmund Siegmund still needs to find a route to make that happen. Back in Berlin, Merz is set for a very uncomfortable morning as his CDU colleagues reckon with the defeat. He's then expected to face the cameras at 1:30 p.m., my Berlin Playbook colleagues report.

Reactions: Donald Trump posted a bar chart showing the result on Truth Social ... Italian Deputy PM Matteo Salvini said the AfD's triumph showed "another Europe is possible" ... France's European Affairs Minister Benjamin Haddad called it a "grave moment" for the continent ... Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk posted that "only idiots or traitors" would celebrate the result in his country. From Brussels officialdom? Nothing so far.

In today's Playbook:

— A shakeup is under way in the European Commission.

— EPP chief Manfred Weber weighs a trip to the crisis-hit Spanish exclave of Ceuta.

— Faces in the crowd: Magdalena Andersson, Ulf Kristersson, Jimmie Åkesson, Kaja Kallas, Ursula von der Leyen, Mette Frederiksen, Kyriakos Mitsotakis, Robin Vink, Tudor Turcu and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick analyze what the AfD's breakthrough in Saxony-Anhalt means for Europe.

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DRIVING THE DAY

RUSSIA INFILTRATION CLAIM ROCKS SWEDEN: With less than a week to go until Sweden's general election, center-left frontrunner Magdalena Andersson told Playbook that her main rival in the race — conservative Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson — must "come clean" about claims that Russia may have infiltrated his likely future coalition partner.

Why it matters: Euroskeptic parties are on the rise, from Germany's Saxony-Anhalt region to France to Stockholm, where the right-wing Sweden Democrats could enter government as Kristersson's coalition partner. Claims about a Sweden Democrats official's alleged ties to Russia echo wider security concerns about the foreign ties of other Euroskeptic parties.

Where things stand: Andersson holds a narrow poll lead ahead of the Sept. 13 vote. But the gap between her coalition and the right-wing grouping led by Kristersson is narrowing. It's unclear what effect, if any, the latest claims will have.

Is the line secure? Andersson, a former Swedish prime minister who polls show is likely to win the election, zeroed in on risks to European security and the confidentiality of EU meetings if Kristersson wins and brings the Sweden Democrats into power.

"Ulf Kristersson must come clean about the security crisis," Andersson told Playbook. "These are extremely serious allegations."

What it's about: A report by non-governmental group Expo alleged a Sweden Democrats official promoted pro-Kremlin narratives for a decade and cultivated ties with a Russian state-backed group. Kristersson has vowed to govern with the Sweden Democrats if elected.

Sounds familiar: Brussels was rattled earlier this year by reports that Hungary's ex-foreign minister was speaking to Moscow during high-level EU gatherings, prompting angst about confidentiality.

Reactions: Kristersson said the Sweden Democrats official should be fired, if the allegations are true: "You can't have people who sit around parliament promoting Russian narratives and work in Swedish parliament," he told local media.

Jimmie Åkesson, leader of the Sweden Democrats, said his party had no knowledge of the claims but would investigate them. (Playbook reached out to Kristersson and Åkesson's parties for comment: the former replied, saying Kristersson stood by his earlier remarks; the Sweden Democrats didn't reply.)

Swed-exit? Andersson said in her interview with POLITICO that Swedes are fed up with Kristersson's right-wing government and want more investment in state services. She also warned that the Sweden Democrats would launch a debate on Sweden's exit from the EU if they win power.

The bottom line: Sweden is among NATO's newest members and one of Ukraine's staunchest supporters on the European scene. Any hint of Russian involvement in national politics is significant not just for Sweden, but all of Europe.

BIG AND BREAKING

KALLAS' DEFENSE GROUP CANCELED: Top EU diplomat Kaja Kallas has been forced to call off this morning's planned launch of a new high-level group of former political and military leaders after some EU members pushed back, Jacopo Barigazzi reports.

ARCTIC PUSH: Commission President Ursula von der Leyen is in Greenland for a two-day visit, where she'll promise more investment and closer political ties as the EU prepares to publish its Arctic strategy later this year, Reuters reports .

CHINA'S LIFELINE TO RUSSIA: A Chinese state-owned company has supplied Russia with the materials required to build hundreds of kamikaze drones , according to internal Russian company shipping documents obtained by POLITICO.

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HELLO, GOODBYE

RENTRÉE RESHUFFLE: Several commissioners' cabinets have said goodbye to familiar faces and brought in new ones over the summer, in a notable shake-up at the highest level of the EU executive, Sebastian Starcevic and Gerardo Fortuna write.

On the 13th floor: Von der Leyen hired a new defense adviser, Robin Vink, replacing Thomas Lunau, who had been seconded from the Danish military for 14 months (as Playbook reported). Vink is also a military man on secondment.

Elsewhere in the Berlaymont: Justice Commissioner Michael McGrath has a new head of cabinet, Kevin Barrett, replacing Fiona Knab-Lunny, who will head to Vienna as EU ambassador to the OSCE. Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu hired Tudor Turcu, who previously worked for the Romanian energy minister, following the departure of Razvan Marc.

Like and subscribe: Youth and Culture Commissioner Glenn Micallef hired policy assistant Eda Kurtoglu, who will help the Instagram-happy commissioner with social media, and said farewell to Deša Srsen; while Anna Modestou will handle social media for Fisheries Commissioner Costas Kadis, replacing Stalo Papanastasiou. Theresa-Sophie Stiegler has joined the cabinet of Executive Vice President Stéphane Séjourné, advising on the single market.

Meanwhile, Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica said farewell to her long-serving deputy head of cabinet Ivo Belet (and posted this sweet message). Belet is retiring and his replacement will be Raúl Hernández i Sagrera.

And breathe ... Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin said goodbye to Marek Nohejl, who's now head of unit at the EU's Service for Foreign Policy Instruments, and farewelled deputy head of cabinet Florentine Hopmeier, who has been on leave for a year and will be deputy head of the Commission representation in Vienna. Neither have been replaced but will be soon.

Is all of this normal? Yeah. A Commission official told Playbook that some movement is typical after a sleepy summer, as Brussels kicks back into gear.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

French President Emmanuel Macron is hosting a space summit in Paris this week, although four U.S. companies have pulled out under pressure from the White House . Washington has also lobbied against the European Commission's EU Space Act — but what is that? It's a plan to create a single market for space activities, boosting the competitiveness of the EU space sector. Brussels, Paris and Berlin don't want Europe's satellite connectivity to depend entirely on SpaceX's Starlink, or other U.S. providers.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Zoya asked for your views on the Saxony-Anhalt election result. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

CEUTA CRISIS COMES TO BRUSSELS

WEBER PLANS CEUTA VISIT: European People's Party chief Manfred Weber is in talks to visit the Spanish exclave of Ceuta in coming weeks, according to two people with knowledge of the plan, Max Griera and Gerardo Fortuna report. Weber's spokesperson declined to comment.

Mounting pressure: The EPP is bringing Ceuta Mayor-President Juan Jesús Vivas, a member of Spain's center-right Popular Party, to Brussels on Tuesday to meet Weber, along with Commissioners Magnus Brunner and Dubravka Šuica, to give his account of the situation in Ceuta. A sit-down with Parliament President Roberta Metsola is expected but not confirmed

The message: The trip aims to build momentum for tougher EU migration rules. "This is about being clear that taking back control of migration means protecting our borders," said Swedish EPP Vice-Chair Tomas Tobé. "We cannot allow a 'Sánchez failure' like this to happen again," he said, referencing

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's migration stance.

From Ceuta to Strasbourg: The EPP is also pushing for a plenary debate in Strasbourg next week, accompanied by a resolution setting out Parliament's position on the crisis. That same week, as Playbook reported, migration will feature prominently in Ursula von der Leyen's State of the Union speech.

Ceuta clue: At Friday's Commission away-day, Brunner presented a report on lessons learned from the Ceuta crisis. He was the only commissioner to make such a presentation — an indication of where migration sits on the SOTEU priority list.

Asylum rules announcement: One idea under consideration for the speech is a European framework for situations of mass migratory pressure, a senior diplomat told POLITICO. That could be to allow the controversial suspension of asylum rules in exceptional circumstances, as pitched in a recent op-ed for POLITICO by Greek PM Kyriakos Mitsotakis.

DASHBOARD

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

GERMAN JITTERS OVER FRENCH DEFENSE TECH: France and Germany want to end their reliance on American military AI technology, but Berlin fears the alternative put forward by Paris may replace one foreign dependency with another .

ROSATOM PLANT DELAYED: A Russian-designed nuclear power plant being built in Hungary will miss its completion date by at least two years , internal documents obtained by POLITICO show.

POLISH FAR RIGHT STOKES ANTI-UKRAINIAN SENTIMENT: The nationalist right is turning hostility toward Poland's roughly 1.5 million Ukrainians into a potent political issue , Wojciech Kość reports.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Partly cloudy, top of 26C.

E-SOOTERS ON THE MIND: EU ministers' informal General Affairs Council in Dublin last week unexpectedly got into the thorny issue of e-scooter rules over a pint. "This is an issue in many European countries," Ireland's Europe Affairs Minister Thomas Byrne told Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich. "These new devices can be very, very useful, but in the wrong hands can be lethal."

CHILL ON THE ASBESTOS: Tests carried out this summer ahead of major renovations to the European Parliament's Churchill building in Strasbourg, which houses many MEPs' offices, hit a snag when asbestos was found. The EP press service told Sonja Rijnen the material is being removed by a certified contractor and air quality has been monitored throughout the work and no asbestos fibers have been detected (asbestos only poses a health risk when fibers become airborne and are inhaled).

Been there: It's not the first time asbestos has been found at the Parliament. In 2013, renovation work in the same building released asbestos fibers, potentially exposing more than 330 officials, staff and workers. Three defendants were later acquitted in a criminal trial. Asbestos was also found and removed from an EP building in Brussels in 2015.

Churchill makeover: The latest tests were part of the preparatory phase for larger renovations of the Churchill building's hall, where the famous Swan Bar is located. The works aim to "meet new legal obligations in terms of accessibility, environment and building standards, and ensure the technical compliance of equipment," according to the press service. The main renovation is expected to begin by the end of this year and will take place outside parliamentary sessions.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The AfD will spend today maneuvering to install Ulrich Siegmund as premier of Saxony-Anhalt, while Friedrich Merz faces a reckoning over the CDU's defeat.

Paris: French moderates sounded the alarm about the AfD's breakthrough in Saxony-Anhalt — but the National Rally's rift with its German counterpart shows no sign of healing.

London: Chancellor John Healey will have his first real chance to set out an economic philosophy in a major speech today.

Washington: Republicans face historical headwinds as the midterm campaign kicks into high gear — but several big unknowns could still sway the race.

Canberra: Labor's "digital duty of care" legislation is set to spark a divisive debate over whether the proposal will help children, harm free speech or ... both.

AGENDA

— Commission President Ursula von der Leyen visits Greenland, where she meets with Prime Minister Jens-Frederik Nielsen and Danish Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič receives U.K. European Relations Minister Hamish Falconer and Paraguayan Foreign Minister Rubén Ramírez Lezcano.

— High Representative Kaja Kallas meets Lithuanian President Gitanas Nausėda and Prime Minister Mindaugas Sinkevičius.

— Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen participates in the informal agriculture ministers meeting in Dublin.

— Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis holds a virtual meeting with Ukrainian Prime Minister Serhii Kiretskyi.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall receives Japanese Environment Minister Hirofumi Yoshino.

— Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner has a phone call with Dutch Migration Minister Bart van den Brink.

BIRTHDAYS

Member of Bulgarian National Assembly Iskra Mihaylova; Dutch politician Vicky Maeijer; former MEP József Szájer; POLITICO's Zoya Sheftalovich; European Commission's Ilze Juhansone and Telmo Baltazar; The Economist's Matthew Holehouse; Verfassungsblog's Max Steinbeis; Catarina Martins, MEP and POLITICO 28 alum; Marian Godina, Romanian police officer/social media sensation and POLITICO 28 alum.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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